

Memory versus Monument Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 30-45 min

Category	History	Time	30-45 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	memory-versus-monument

Big idea: Public memory and historical knowledge overlap, but they are not the same practice.

Overview

Students compare personal memory, public memorials, and archival evidence as different ways of knowing the past.

Student Prompt

Inspect Memory versus Monument Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Memory versus Monument Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Fictional memorial: a plaque celebrating a former headteacher beside a diary extract from a student and a board meeting note. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Memory versus Monument Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Comparison prompt: What does each source ask the public to remember?. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Memory versus Monument Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Comparison prompt: What does each source ask the public to remember?. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Public memory and historical knowledge overlap, but they are not the same practice.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Memory versus Monument Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Memory versus Monument Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	How is public memory different from historical knowledge?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how public memory and historical knowledge overlap, but they are not the same practice.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Use a local or familiar memorial only if the class context is suitable; otherwise use a fictional school memorial.
- Prepare three sources with clearly different purposes.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Fictional memorial: a plaque celebrating a former headteacher beside a diary extract from a student and a board meeting note.
- Comparison prompt: What does each source ask the public to remember?

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Show a memorial image and ask what knowledge it seems to communicate.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Give a personal memory and an archival source about the same event.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Students compare purpose, evidence, emotion, and omissions.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Groups decide what each source helps us know and what it cannot settle.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
5	Debrief the difference between remembering and explaining the past.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- A memorial is not a textbook page; it is a public act of selection.
- What kind of truth is the memorial trying to preserve?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat sources as transparent windows rather than selected traces.
- Students may confuse explaining context with excusing actions.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Uses source evidence while naming selection, silence, and perspective.
- Distinguishes historical claim, interpretation, and judgement.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Support: use a fictional school example.
- Challenge: include two public audiences with competing needs.

Extension Tasks

- Students design a revised plaque with a short note about what it includes and excludes.
- Connect to debates about museums, statues, and national memory.

Related Activities

- Presentism Trial
- Broken Archive
- Same Event, Different Historian